5.1.1 CENTRE OF MASS

When a rigid body moves, all particles that constitute the body need not take the same path. Depending on the type of motion, different particles of the body may take different paths. For example, when a wheel rolls on a surface, the path of the centre point of the wheel and the paths of other points of the wheel are different. In this Unit, we study about the translation, rotation and the combination of these motions of rigid bodies in detail.

5.1.2 Centre of Mass of a Rigid Body

When a bulk object (say a bat) is thrown at an angle in air as shown in Figure 5.1; do all the points of the body take a parabolic path? Actually, only one point takes the parabolic path and all the other points take different paths.

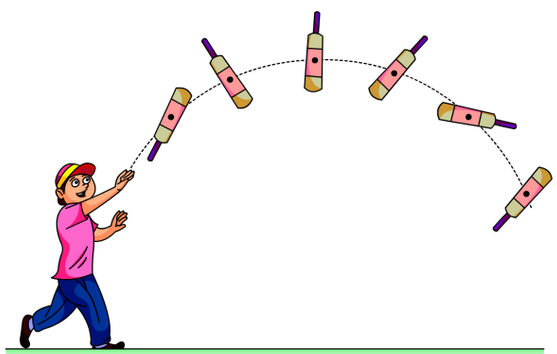


Figure 5.1 Centre of mass tracing the path of a parabola

The one point that takes the parabolic path is a very special point called *centre of mass* (CM) of the body. Its motion is like the motion of a single point that is thrown. *The centre of mass of a body is defined as a point where the entire mass of the body appears to be concentrated.* Therefore, this point can represent the entire body.

For bodies of regular shape and uniform mass distribution, the centre of mass is at the geometric centre of the body. As examples, for a circle and sphere, the centre of mass is at their centres; for square and rectangle, at the point their diagonals meet; for cube and cuboid, it is at the point where their body diagonals meet. For other bodies, the centre of mass has to be determined using some methods. The centre of mass could be well within the body and in some cases outside the body as well.

5.1.3 Centre of Mass for Distributed Point Masses

A point mass is a hypothetical point particle which has nonzero mass and no size or shape. To find the centre of mass for a collection of n point masses, say, m_1, m_2, m_3 . . . m_n we have to first choose an origin and an appropriate coordinate system as shown in Figure 5.2. Let, x_1, x_2, x_3 . . . x_n be the X-coordinates of the positions of these point masses in the X direction from the origin.

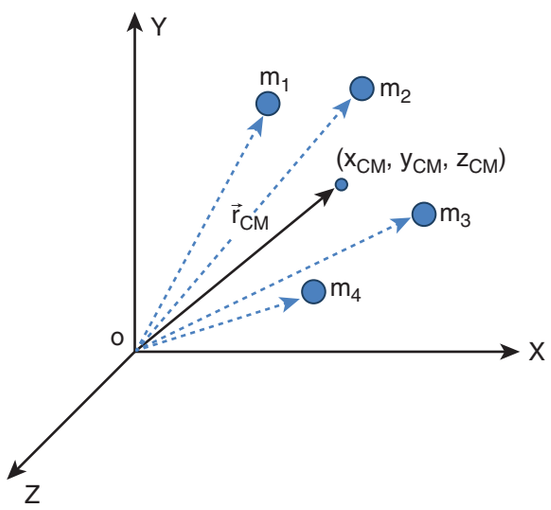


Figure 5.2 Centre of mass for distributed point masses

UNIT-5(XI-Physics_Vol-1).indd 209 06-01-2022 17:46:17